

Toward a More Perfect Union

Modern America • 1964–Present | Standards US.83, US.84, US.85, US.86, US.87, US.88, US.89, US.90, US.91, US.92, US.93, US.94, US.95

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

This is the last stop, and it runs right up to your own front door. In sixty years America argued about almost everything — how big government should be, whether it could be trusted, what it owed the poor and the planet, how to keep itself safe, and who was allowed to lead. It broke a president, ended a Cold War, was attacked on its own soil, and elected a Black president in the same century a Tennessee balcony took the movement's greatest leader. After 130 years of watching the gap between America's promise and its practice, the last question is the one only you can answer: is the union still becoming more perfect — and what will you do with it?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

Great Society	Johnson's 1960s programs to fight poverty and injustice, including Medicare and Medicaid.	counterculture	The 1960s youth movement that rejected mainstream values, authority, and war.
Watergate	The scandal and cover-up that forced President Nixon to resign in 1974.	stagflation	High inflation and high unemployment at the same time — the economic crisis of the 1970s.
Reaganomics	Reagan's policy of tax cuts and higher military spending to grow the economy.	War on Terror	The U.S. response to the 9/11 attacks, including wars in Afghanistan and Iraq.
the tech revolution	The shift from landlines and letters to personal computers, the internet, and smartphones.	a more perfect union	The Constitution's goal — the never-finished work of making the country live up to its promise.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze Johnson's Great Society and the 1960s counterculture as two very different responses to the question of what America should become. Notice: Two revolutions at once. In Washington, a president tries to build a 'Great Society' — declaring war on poverty itself and creating health care... Debrief: Describe two major programs of the Great Society and their goals. Then explain what the 'generation gap' and counterculture were rejecting. How were these two 1960s movements different visions of America's future?	Great Society programs: Medicare/Medicaid (health coverage for elderly/poor) and the War on Poverty (education, job training). The counterculture/generation gap rejected traditional values, materialism, authority, and the Vietnam War, embracing peace and new music. The two were different visions: the Great Society sought to improve society through government action, while the counterculture sought change by rejecting mainstream institutions and values. Strong answers contrast the two visions.
2	Analyze Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and China opening, and the Watergate scandal that proved no one is above the law. Notice: A president pulls off one of the boldest moves in the history of American diplomacy — flying to communist China to shake the hand of a man his... Debrief: Explain Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and his opening to China. Then explain what Watergate was and why United States v. Nixon mattered. What does Watergate teach about limits on presidential power?	The 'silent majority' strategy appealed to mainstream Americans uneasy with 1960s protest, building a conservative coalition; the 1972 China trip eased Cold War tensions. Watergate was a break-in and White House cover-up; United States v. Nixon (1974) forced release of the tapes, proving no one — not even the president — is above the law, and Nixon resigned. It teaches that constitutional checks (courts, Congress, press) can hold a president accountable. Strong answers address the limits on presidential power.
3	Analyze the rise of the modern environmental movement and its landmark laws and conflicts. Notice: A river so polluted it literally caught fire. A book that revealed the pesticides in your food were killing the birds. A neighborhood built on a... Debrief: Explain what sparked the modern environmental movement and describe two laws or agencies it created. Then explain the conflict the snail-darter case revealed. Why might environmental protection sometimes clash with other goals?	It grew from alarm over pollution, sparked by Silent Spring (1962) and the first Earth Day (1970). It created the EPA, the Clean Air Act, the Clean Water Act, and Superfund. The snail-darter case (TVA v. Hill, 1978) pitted a development project (Tellico Dam) against protecting an endangered species under the Endangered Species Act. Environmental protection can clash with goals like jobs, energy, and development, forcing hard trade-offs. Strong answers explain that tension.
4	Analyze Carter's presidency — stagflation and the energy crisis, the Camp David triumph, and the Iran Hostage Crisis. Notice: Imagine prices going up AND jobs disappearing at the same time — the two things that aren't supposed to happen together, both happening at once.... Debrief: Explain what 'stagflation' and the energy crisis were and how they affected Americans. Then contrast Carter's greatest success (Camp David) with his greatest failure (Iran). Was Carter's reputation as a 'failed' president fair? Defend your answer.	Stagflation was simultaneous high inflation and unemployment; the energy crisis brought soaring oil prices and gas lines, squeezing families. Carter's success: the Camp David Accords (1978), a historic Egypt–Israel peace. His failure: the Iran Hostage Crisis (52 Americans, 444 days), which with the economy cost him the 1980 election. Strong answers weigh the historic achievement against the crises (some beyond his control) and take a defensible position on the fairness of his reputation.
5	Analyze the Reagan Revolution — its economic policy, its social costs and conflicts, and its Cold War pressure on the Soviet Union. Notice: After a decade of gas lines, hostages, and self-doubt, a former movie actor stood up and told Americans it was 'Morning in America' again — that... Debrief: Explain 'Reaganomics' and one result of it. Describe Reagan's approach to the Cold War. Then identify one social cost or conflict of the Reagan era. Why is it important to weigh both sides of this presidency?	Reaganomics cut taxes and raised military spending; results include economic growth but a roughly tripled national debt. On the Cold War, Reagan confronted the USSR aggressively ('tear down this wall'), which supporters credit with helping end it. Costs/conflicts: the War on Drugs and mass incarceration with racial disparities, the criticized AIDS response, and rising inequality. Weighing both sides matters because this is contested, recent history where an honest account must present multiple perspectives. Strong answers give the achievements and the costs.
6	Analyze how George H.W. Bush managed the peaceful end of the Cold War and led a coalition in the Gulf War. Notice: The wall came down. The enemy America had feared for 45 years — the one with thousands of nuclear missiles aimed at your grandparents — simply... Debrief: Explain how the Cold War ended under Bush and why his restraint mattered. Then describe the Gulf War and Bush's coalition-building approach. Why was leaving Saddam Hussein in power a debated decision?	The Cold War ended peacefully (Berlin Wall fell 1989, USSR collapsed 1991); Bush's restraint mattered because gloating could have destabilized a still-nuclear USSR. The Gulf War (1991) answered Iraq's invasion of Kuwait; Bush built a broad UN-backed coalition, and Desert Storm won in 100 hours. Leaving Saddam in power was debated because it kept a hostile dictator in place — a choice questioned especially after the later Iraq War. Strong answers explain the restraint and the coalition, and the debate over stopping short.
7	Analyze the Clinton-era economy and the communication-technology revolution that reshaped how Americans live. Notice: Somewhere in the 1990s, the whole world moved into your pocket. In a single generation, America went from landlines, letters, and encyclopedias on... Debrief: Describe how communication technology changed from the 1970s to today, with two examples, including one benefit and one challenge. Then explain the Clinton-era economy and the debate over NAFTA. How did technology and the economy connect?	Technology went from landlines/letters to the PC (1981), the internet (1990s), and smartphones/social media — a benefit is connection/access; a challenge is misinformation or privacy loss. The Clinton economy boomed on the tech sector and reached the first balanced budget since 1969; NAFTA (1993) expanded free trade (supporters: bigger markets; critics: lost factory jobs). Technology and the economy connected because the internet/tech sector drove the boom. Strong answers give a benefit and a challenge and explain the connection.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
8	Analyze the September 11, 2001 attacks and the War on Terror they set in motion. Notice: On an ordinary bright Tuesday morning, the country you've been studying for ten units was attacked at home — not by an army, but by nineteen men... Debrief: Explain what happened on September 11, 2001, and how the United States responded. Then explain the debate the USA PATRIOT Act raised. How does that debate connect to earlier moments in this course?	On 9/11, al-Qaeda hijacked four planes, killing nearly 3,000 people (the deadliest terrorist attack in U.S. history). The U.S. responded with the War on Terror (wars in Afghanistan and Iraq). The PATRIOT Act expanded surveillance, raising a debate over security vs. civil liberties. It connects to earlier moments like the Red Scare and Japanese American internment, when fear also tempted the country to restrict freedom. Strong answers make that historical connection.
9	Analyze the breaking of barriers for women and minorities in government, culminating in the election of the first African American president — and... Notice: Go back to Unit 1. In 1877, a Black Southerner couldn't safely vote, a woman couldn't vote at all, and the idea of either one leading the country... Debrief: Give three examples of women or minorities breaking barriers in government. Then explain why Obama's 2008 election was historic, and its context. Finally: looking across the whole course from 1877 to 2009, has the country moved closer to 'a more perfect union'? Defend your answer with evidence from at least two units.	Barrier-breakers: O'Connor (first woman on the Supreme Court), Powell/Rice (first Black Secretaries of State), Pelosi (first woman Speaker), Hillary Clinton (senator/Secretary of State/candidate). Obama's 2008 election was historic as the first African American president, amid the worst financial crisis since the Depression; he signed the ACA amid sharp partisan division. Strong answers argue a defensible position on the 130-year arc using specific evidence from at least two units (e.g., disenfranchisement in Unit 1 vs. Obama in Unit 10; the civil-rights movement's gains and its unfinished work), acknowledging both progress and what remains undone.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 10 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **President Johnson signs Medicare and Medicaid into law in 1965 (with former President Truman beside him) — a cornerstone of the Great Society.**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *This is President Johnson signing Medicare in 1965, with former President Truman — who had tried and failed to pass health insurance — beside him....*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.83/84. Treat both the Great Society and counterculture fairly. Danny continuity from Units 7/8. TN anchor: Appalachian War on Poverty + Medicare/Medicaid.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1965	The Great Society builds a safety net	Climb Broadly seen as a major expansion of health and anti-poverty protection, though its size and effectiveness are debated — so consensus is marked...
1974	Watergate: the system holds	Mixed Both a vindication of constitutional checks and a lasting wound to public trust — genuinely two-sided, so marked mixed and contested.
1970	The environmental movement wins protection	Climb Broadly regarded as a major and durable advance in protecting public health and the environment.
1991	The Cold War ends peacefully	Climb Broadly celebrated as a peaceful, hopeful end to a dangerous 45-year standoff.
2001	The September 11 attacks	Setback Universally regarded as a catastrophic attack and national tragedy — an unambiguous setback.
2009	The first African American president	Climb Widely seen as a historic milestone in the long struggle for racial equality, even as the country remained sharply divided — so consensus is...

B Debrief & Closing Argument

This is where the whole course comes home. For ten units and 130 years, you've measured America against its own founding promise — 'a more perfect...

Closing question: You've now traveled the entire arc, from 1877 to today. Looking back across all ten units, argue whether the United States has, on balance, moved closer to its founding promise of 'a more perfect union' — using at least three moments from different units as evidence. Then, because this is your country now: name one part of the promise you think is still unfinished, and one thing your generation could do about it. There's no answer key. This one is yours to write.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.